

Petition 4 — Special Status and Pollution-Category Parity for the Coir (De-fibring & Pith) Industry in Chittur

To: Shri P.K. Kunhalikutty Hon'ble Minister for Industries & Commerce, Government of Kerala Thiruvananthapuram

Copy to: 1. Shri Ramesh Chennithala, Hon'ble Minister in charge of Coir 2. The Chairman, Kerala State Pollution Control Board

From: The Chittur Agriculture Marketing Society, Kozhinjampara, Chittur Taluk, Palakkad District — represented by [Name, designation] and delegation.

Through: Adv. Sumesh Achuthan, MLA, Chittur Constituency.

Date: 15 July 2026, Thiruvananthapuram.

Subject: Request for special status and pollution-category parity for coir de-fibring and coir-pith processing units in Chittur, so that the coir industry can develop within Kerala instead of migrating across the border to Pollachi (Tamil Nadu).

1. Respected Sir,

Chittur adjoins the Pollachi belt of Tamil Nadu and has abundant coconut and coir-husk availability. Yet the primary coir-processing industry has migrated almost entirely to Pollachi, chiefly because of a **difference in pollution-control classification** between the two States. We pray for a level playing field.

2. The factual position

- 1. The classification gap.** The primary coir processes — **coconut-husk retting, de-fibring, and coir-pith processing** — are treated far more stringently by the Kerala State Pollution Control Board (historically in the **Red / Orange** category) than in Tamil Nadu. In **October 2023 the Tamil Nadu Pollution Control Board withdrew its earlier "Orange" reclassification and retained coir husk-retting, de-fibring and pith-processing in the "White" (practically non-polluting) category.**
- 2. The consequence.** Because of this gap, the **polluting / primary processes (de-fibring, pith buffering) are carried out in Pollachi**, while only value-addition (mats, yarn, mattings, geotextiles) is done in Kerala. Coir entrepreneurs — including many from Kerala — have set up primary units in Pollachi, taking away investment, jobs and the value of our own coconut husk.
- 3. CPCB norms actually permit a lighter category.** The **CPCB Directions dated 07-03-2016** (No. B-29012/ESS(CPA)/2015-16), issued under **Section 18(1)(b) of the Water (Prevention and Control of Pollution) Act, 1974**, harmonised the classification on a **Pollution Index (PI)** basis — **Red (PI ≥ 60), Orange (41–59), Green (21–40), White (≤ 20)** — and this has been carried forward by the **CPCB Directions dated 12-02-2025**. Under this methodology and the current classification, coir is placed at a **much lighter category than Red**: - Coir **fibre / pith processing generating effluent** — **Green**; - Coir fibre / pith processing and manufacture of coir products by **dry process** — **White**; - Only coir **bleaching / dyeing / printing** — **Orange**.

For comparison, the **TNPCB Board Proceedings dated 10-11-2021** briefly moved coir from White to Orange, but this was **withdrawn in 2023**, retaining coconut-husk retting, de-fibring and pith-processing in the **White** category in Tamil Nadu. In other words, a blanket Red/Orange treatment of ordinary de-fibring and dry pith processing in Kerala is **stricter than the CPCB norm requires**, and the Kerala State Pollution Control Board can align (under the same 2016/2025 Directions) without diluting genuine environmental safeguards.

3. Our prayer

We humbly request the Hon'ble Minister, in coordination with the Coir portfolio and the Kerala State Pollution Control Board, to:

1. **Re-align the pollution-category of coir de-fibring and dry coir-pith processing** in Kerala to **Green / White**, consistent with the CPCB 2016 methodology and the 2023/2025 classification, so that such units are viable in Chittur while dyeing/bleaching alone remains regulated.
2. Grant **special coir-cluster / coir industrial-zone status for Chittur**, with a Special Purpose Vehicle and a **Common Facility Centre** (mechanised de-fibring, pith washing / block-making with **Zero-Liquid-Discharge and effluent / salinity management**), so that environmental concerns are addressed collectively and cost-effectively.
3. Provide **fiscal incentives** — capital subsidy, interest subvention, and **power-tariff parity with Tamil Nadu** — to attract coir units to Chittur.
4. Ensure a **level playing field with Pollachi** so that the value addition to Kerala's own coconut husk is retained within Kerala, generating local employment.

4. Annexures (to be attached)

- Annexure A: Comparative note — KSPCB vs. TNPCB coir classification and CPCB norms.
- Annexure B: Estimated husk availability and employment potential in Chittur.

Respectfully submitted,

For and on behalf of the Chittur Agriculture Marketing Society, Kozhinjampara

[Name, Designation] [Phone / Email]

Endorsed by: Adv. Sumesh Achuthan, MLA, Chittur

Annexure — Draft Government Order (model, for the Government's consideration)

The following is a model draft placed for the Government's consideration. The actual G.O. number, date and file references are to be assigned by the Department.

GOVERNMENT OF KERALA
Abstract

Industries Department — Coir sector in Chittur (Palakkad) — Alignment of the pollution-category of coir de-fibring and dry coir-pith processing with the CPCB Directions, and grant of special coir-cluster status with a Common Facility Centre — Orders issued.

INDUSTRIES (COIR) DEPARTMENT
G.O.(Ms) No. ____/2026/ID Thiruvananthapuram, dated __-__-2026

Read: 1. CPCB Directions dated 07-03-2016 (No. B-29012/ESS(CPA)/2015-16) u/s 18(1)(b) of the Water (Prevention and Control of Pollution) Act, 1974, and CPCB Directions dated 12-02-2025.
2. TNPCB proceedings dated 10-11-2021 and their withdrawal (2023).
3. Representation dated 15-07-2026 of the Chittur Agriculture Marketing Society, Kozhinjampara, forwarded by the MLA, Chittur.

ORDER

Whereas the primary coir processes (husk retting, de-fibring, dry pith processing) are treated more stringently in Kerala than the CPCB PI-based norm requires, causing these units and their employment to migrate to Pollachi (Tamil Nadu), where they are in the White category;

Government, having considered the matter, hereby order that —

(1) the Kerala State Pollution Control Board shall re-align the category of coir de-fibring and dry coir-pith processing to Green/White, consistent with the CPCB Directions read above (1), retaining regulation only for bleaching/dyeing;
(2) a special coir-cluster / coir industrial-zone status is accorded to

Chittur, with an SPV and a Common Facility Centre (mechanised de-fibring, pith washing/block-making with Zero-Liquid-Discharge and salinity management);

(3) capital subsidy, interest subvention and power-tariff parity with Tamil Nadu shall be extended to coir units in Chittur; and

(4) the Industries and Coir Directorates shall ensure a level playing field so that value addition to Kerala's coconut husk is retained within the State.

By order of the Governor,

Secretary to Government

To The Director of Industries & Commerce; the Director of Coir Development; the Chairman, Kerala State Pollution Control Board.

Copy to: the Minister for Coir; Environment Dept.; the MLA, Chittur.